Plan of Research: AI-Mediated Communication in Collective Creative Practice

Whose Contribution Counts? Generative AI, Cultural Participation and Collective Authorship in Research-Creation

Proposed Plan of Study, PhD in Communication & Culture, Fall 2027

Roman Jahandideh

I am an artistic practitioner and researcher working through research-creation, trained in architecture and landscape architecture and now building interactive 3D and game environments. My doctoral project asks how generative AI (GenAI), meaning the models, interfaces and platforms that own them, is reorganizing cultural participation: who can make meaning with these systems, whose contributions become visible, who can refuse a model's interpretation, and who receives credit or answers for the result. Its central question is: how does collaborative artistic practice with GenAI redistribute participation, cultural voice and authorship, and how can research-creation make those redistributions visible and contestable? The stakes reach beyond any one tool. Interpretive authority is concentrating in proprietary platforms, models can standardize culturally situated expression, and artists' work is taken into training data without consent.

My objects of study are collective art-making with a selected ecology of GenAI and non-AI tools, and the artwork it produces. Using the program's research-creation option, the project has five phases: my own studio inquiry into collaboration and GenAI; consultations with four to six practitioners; a series of workshops with about 18–24 adult artists, performers, designers and creative technologists in three cohorts, in which I conduct participant observation; semi-structured focus groups with each cohort; and the co-creation of a large collaborative artwork proposed for exhibition at York's Markham Campus. Analysis combines thematic, episode and artifact analysis. Every activity has a non-AI route.

The project would contribute a communication-and-culture account of how GenAI mediation redistributes recognition and creative authority, a research-creation method for studying it, and an artwork and protocols that make those relations perceptible in public. It belongs to Technology in Practice, with Media & Culture as a minor, and to the program's aim of promoting "the application of critical theory and research." I hope to work with Dr. Rebecca Caines, whose research on improvisation as methodology, socially responsive creative technologies and GenAI as a critical improvisation practice grounds this approach.

Each stage of my training asked how designed environments shape the way people perceive and relate to one another. In architecture at Tabriz Islamic Art University (Best Dissertation Award, 2016), I designed space as a medium of social life, where thresholds and paths decide who gathers and is seen. Landscape architecture at Istanbul Technical University extended this to public space; in its Virtual Landscape Lab I studied how people perceive mediated environments (eCAADe 2023). At Simon Fraser University's iViz Lab, my thesis research moved from space to interfaces: I build multiplayer worlds and physiological interfaces in Unity and C# and study them with participants, in work accepted at ACM ISS 2026. Participants accepted a shared heart-rate cue only if they controlled who saw it, a communication question about who controls how a system represents people. The PhD carries it into collective artistic practice.